Tellingly, from the early 1990s, the first BJP political breakthroughs came in areas with significant Muslim populations. The creation of a Hindu political identity worked best in areas where the 'Other' was seen as a threat. This led to a Hindu consolidation of voters, just as there was Muslim consolidation against the BJP. While the Muslim vote could be split between the Congress and other regional forces, the Hindu votes counter-mobilised and coalesced around the BJP. There is a strong pattern of its dominance in these Muslim-dominated areas in national elections between 1991 and 2019. The BJP won its first Assam Lok Sabha seats in 1991 in the southernmost tip of the state: Karimganj and Silchar. Of these, Karimganj is a Muslim-dominant (56.36 per cent) constituency.[148] Even Silchar had a 12 per cent Muslim population. In 1996, the BJP won Karimganj again, its lone victory in that election. In 1999, it won two Lok Sabha seats: Nowgong (Nagaon) and Guwahati in Upper Assam. Of these, Nagaon district had a Muslim population of 55.36 per cent,[149] while Guwahati had 12.45 per cent Muslims. In 2004, the BJP won again in Nagaon and Mangaldoi (27.59 per cent Muslim population).[150] The pattern repeated in 2009, when the BJP won four Lok Sabha seats: Mangaldoi, Guwahati, Nagaon and Silchar. It was only in 2014, when it won seven parliamentary seats (three of these with a significant Muslim presence) and 2019, when it had a majority of nine seats, that the percentage of Muslim-dominant seats in its portfolio declined. Even then, over 40 per cent of its wins were in seats with a significant Muslim presence.

Table 16.10: The BJP Grew through Hindu Consolidation in Muslim-significant Seats in Assam

Year	*Lok Sabha Seats Won by BJP in Assam*	*Muslim-significant Lok Sabha Seats Won by BJP in Assam*	*Muslim-significant Seats BJP Won of Its Assam Tally %*
1980	0	0	–
1984	0	0	–
1989	0	0	–